

URUH 4701

Final Questions

1. Assess the administrative reforms of Abdul Malik ibn Marwan. How did these reforms contribute to the development of Islamic governance and modern civilization?
2. Analyze the policies of Umar ibn Abdul Aziz. How did these policies reflect the legacy of the Khulafa-i-Rashideen?
3. Analyze the causes behind the decline and fall of the Umayyad Khilafah ?
4. Examine the contributions of Abu Ja'far al-Mansur as the real founder of the Abbasid Khilafah and evaluate his role in the development of Islamic civilization?
5. Evaluate the contributions of Muslim scholars to the development of Geography and Mathematics. How has modern civilization benefited from these scientific contributions?
6. “The reign of Al-Ma'mun was unquestionably the most brilliant and glorious period in the history of Islam.” Evaluate this statement with pragmatic reasons?
7. Appreciate the contributions of Muslims to the development of Geography and Astronomy. How is modern civilization indebted to these developments?
8. Write short notes on any two of the following:
 - Conquest of India during the reign of Al-Walid I
 - Conquest of Spain during the reign of Al-Walid I
 - Foreign Policy of Harun al-Rashid
 - Bayt al-Hikmah
 - Status of non-Muslims during the Umayyad Caliphate

১। আব্দুল মালিক ইবনে মারওয়ানের প্রশাসনিক সংস্কারসমূহ মূল্যায়ন কর। এসব সংস্কার কীভাবে ইসলামী শাসনব্যবস্থা ও আধুনিক সভ্যতার বিকাশে অবদান রেখেছে?

২। উমর ইবনে আবদুল আজিজের নীতিসমূহ বিশ্লেষণ কর। এসব নীতি কীভাবে খুলাফায়ে রাশেদীনের আদর্শকে প্রতিফলিত করেছে?

৩। উমাইয়া খেলাফতের পতন ও অবক্ষয়ের কারণসমূহ বিশ্লেষণ কর।

৪। আবু জাফর আল-মানসুরকে আব্বাসীয় খেলাফতের প্রকৃত প্রতিষ্ঠাতা হিসেবে তাঁর অবদান এবং ইসলামী সভ্যতার বিকাশে তাঁর ভূমিকা মূল্যায়ন কর।

৫। ভূগোল ও গণিতের উন্নয়নে মুসলিম মনীষীদের অবদান মূল্যায়ন কর। আধুনিক সভ্যতা এসব বৈজ্ঞানিক অবদান থেকে কীভাবে উপকৃত হয়েছে?

৬। “মামুনের শাসনকাল ইসলামের ইতিহাসে নিঃসন্দেহে সবচেয়ে উজ্জ্বল ও গৌরবময় যুগ ছিল।” বাস্তবসম্মত যুক্তিসহ উক্তিটির মূল্যায়ন কর।

৭। ভূগোল ও জ্যোতির্বিজ্ঞানের উন্নয়নে মুসলমানদের অবদান আলোচনা কর। আধুনিক সভ্যতা এসব উন্নয়নের কাছে কীভাবে ঋণী?

৮। নিম্নের যেকোনো দুটি বিষয়ে সংক্ষিপ্ত টীকা লিখঃ

আল-ওয়ালিদ প্রথমের শাসনামলে ভারত বিজয়

আল-ওয়ালিদ প্রথমের শাসনামলে স্পেন বিজয়

হারুন আল-রশীদের বৈদেশিক নীতি

বাইতুল হিকমাহ

উমাইয়া খেলাফতে অমুসলিমদের অবস্থান

1. Assess the administrative reforms of Abdul Malik ibn Marwan. How did these reforms contribute to the development of Islamic governance and modern civilization

Introduction

Abdul Malik ibn Marwan was a very powerful ruler of the Umayyad Empire. He ruled from 685 to 705 CE. When he became the leader, the empire was facing many problems and wars. With his smart ideas, he solved these problems and brought peace. He changed the empire from a weak group of regions into a single, strong nation. This is why historians call him the "real builder" of the Islamic state.

Abdul Malik ibn Marwan's Reforms

1. Making Arabic the Official Language

Before Abdul Malik, government offices used different languages:

- Greek in Syria
- Coptic in Egypt
- Persian (Pahlavi) in Iraq

He ordered that Arabic should be used in all government records and administration.

Results:

- The empire became more united.
- Communication became easier.
- Arabic grew into an international language of law, science, literature, and culture.

2. Creating an Islamic Currency

People previously used Byzantine and Persian coins.

Abdul Malik introduced:

- Islamic gold Dinar
- Islamic silver Dirham

These coins carried Arabic inscriptions and Islamic beliefs instead of images of rulers.

Results:

- The Muslim state became economically independent.
- Trade became easier and more stable.
- The coins showed the political and religious identity of the Islamic state.

3. Improving the Postal System (Barid)

He developed a strong postal and communication network.

He:

- Built stations along major roads.
- Provided fresh horses for messengers.
- Created organized routes for delivering messages.

Results:

- The government could quickly receive news from distant provinces.
- Rebellions could be controlled faster.
- The empire became more centralized and efficient.

4. Infrastructure and Architecture

Abdul Malik sponsored major public projects.

His most famous achievement was the construction of the Dome of the Rock in Jerusalem in 691 CE.

He also improved:

- Roads
- Canals
- Travel routes
- Public infrastructure

Results:

- Trade and transportation improved.
- Islamic architecture developed its own unique style.
- The state's authority became more visible.

Overall Importance

Abdul Malik's reforms introduced ideas that are still important in modern states:

1. Centralized Government – one strong administration for the whole country.
2. Common Official Language – Arabic for law and administration.
3. National Currency – a unified monetary system.
4. Efficient Communication – a strong postal and information network.
5. Public Infrastructure – roads, buildings, and transport systems.

Because of these achievements, many historians consider Abdul Malik one of the most important rulers in early Islamic history and a key architect of the Islamic state.

Conclusion

In conclusion, Abdul Malik ibn Marwan was an amazing leader who made the empire modern and organized. By introducing one common language, a

single currency, a fast postal system, and beautiful buildings, he gave the Islamic world a new identity. His clever ideas are still used by countries today. He did not just expand the empire; he built a solid foundation that helped the Islamic state last for a very long time.

2. Analyze the policies of Umar ibn Abdul Aziz. How did these policies reflect the legacy of the Khulafa-i-Rashideen?

Introduction

Umar ibn Abdul Aziz (Umar II) was an exceptional ruler of the Umayyad Caliphate from 717 to 720 CE. Even though he ruled for only two and a half years, his reign is highly celebrated in Islamic history. He is often called the "Fifth Rightly Guided Caliph" (*Khulafa-i-Rashideen*). This is because he abandoned the luxurious lifestyle of previous kings and brought back the simple, just, and holy governance of the early days of Islam.

Here is how his main policies directly followed the legacy of the *Khulafa-i-Rashideen*.

1. Fair Taxes and Economic Justice

Under earlier Umayyad rulers, the empire focused heavily on collecting money, often using unfair methods. Umar II changed this to help the people.

- **No Tax on New Muslims:** Before him, the government made non-Arab converts pay a heavy tax (*jizya*) just to keep the treasury full. Umar II stopped this immediately. He famously said that the Prophet Muhammad was sent to guide people, not to collect taxes.
- **Public Money for Public Good:** He treated the state treasury (*Bayt al-Mal*) as public property. It was no longer a personal bank account for the royal family.
- **Following the Legacy:** This policy perfectly matched the rules of Abu Bakr and Umar ibn al-Khattab, who believed that all Muslims—Arab or non-Arab—must be treated equally under the law.

2. Stopping Royal Privileges and Corruption

Before becoming the Caliph, Umar II lived a very luxurious life. But when he took power, he gave up all his wealth to lead by example.

- **Giving Back Wealth:** He returned his own expensive lands, wealth, and his wife's jewelry to the public treasury.
- **Taking from the Rich:** He took away lands and properties that other royal princes had stolen or taken unfairly from the people.
- **Following the Legacy:** This mirrors the strict honesty of Umar ibn al-Khattab and Ali ibn Abi Talib. Both of these caliphs fought hard against nepotism (helping family members) and never allowed rulers to get rich from public money.

3. Better Human Rights and Honest Leaders

Umar II cared more about peace, justice, and the well-being of his citizens than expanding the empire through wars.

- **Removing Bad Governors:** He fired corrupt and cruel governors across the empire and replaced them with honest, religious, and kind men.
- **Protecting Minorities:** He strictly protected Christians, Jews, and other non-Muslim groups. He made sure their properties and places of worship were safe.
- **Following the Legacy:** He brought back the concept of *Shura* (consulting with wise scholars and community leaders before making decisions), which was the core political system of the early caliphs.

4. Saving Islamic Knowledge

Umar II knew that a good society needs strong moral and educational foundations.

- **Writing Down Hadiths:** He ordered scholars to officially collect and write down the *Hadiths* (the sayings and actions of the Prophet Muhammad) so they would never be lost.
- **Following the Legacy:** This official effort was just like Abu Bakr and Uthman ibn Affan, who worked hard to compile and preserve the Holy Quran for future generations.

Conclusion

Umar ibn Abdul Aziz proved to the world that a massive empire could be ruled with pure moral values, honesty, and simplicity. By putting justice and the welfare of the people ahead of money and military power, he revived the golden era of Islam. His policies completely broke the chain of imperial corruption, ensuring his place in history as the true successor to the legacy of the Rightly Guided Caliphs.

3. Analyze the causes behind the decline and fall of the Umayyad Khilafah ?

Introduction

The Umayyad Dynasty ruled the Islamic world for nearly 90 years. It was a massive and powerful empire. However, in 750 CE, it completely collapsed. The fall of the Umayyads was not caused by a single event. Instead, it happened due to long-term social, economic, and political problems. Eventually, a new group called the Abbasids overthrew them.

Main Causes of the Decline and Fall

- **1. Bad Treatment of Non-Arab Muslims (*Mawali*):** As the empire grew, many non-Arab people (like Persians and Egyptians) became Muslims. Even though Islam teaches equality, the Umayyad rulers treated Arabs as superior. They forced non-Arab Muslims to pay heavy taxes and kept them away from high government jobs. This made the non-Arabs very angry.
- **2. Fighting Between Arab Tribes:** The Arab ruling class was divided into two big rival groups: the North Arabs and the South Arabs. Instead of uniting the empire, the Umayyad caliphs constantly took sides in these tribal wars. This internal fighting weakened the government and the army.
- **3. The Clever Abbasid Revolution:** The enemies of the Umayyads, known as the Abbasids, started a secret movement. They promised to bring back justice and give leadership to the family of the Prophet Muhammad. This

slogan united all the angry groups. Led by a general named Abu Muslim, they defeated the last Umayyad king at the **Battle of the Zab** in 750 CE.

- **4. Luxury and Loss of Islamic Values:** Most Umayyad kings lived very luxurious lives in expensive palaces. Many Muslims felt that the rulers were neglecting Islamic laws and acting like selfish kings rather than religious leaders. Because of this, the general public and religious scholars lost all respect for them.
- **5. Too Big to Control and Succession Wars:** The empire was huge, stretching from Spain to India. At that time, communication was very slow, making it hard to control faraway regions. Furthermore, there was no clear rule about who would be the next king. As a result, royal family members constantly fought bloody wars against each other for the throne.

Conclusion

In conclusion, the Umayyad Dynasty fell because it failed to keep its people united and happy. While they were great at conquering new lands, they could not build a fair society for all Muslims. Their unfair tax systems, tribal fights, and moral decline made them highly unpopular. In the end, the Abbasids used this public anger to end the Umayyad rule and start a new era.

4. Examine the contributions of Abu Ja'far al-Mansur as the real founder of the Abbasid Khilafah and evaluate his role in the development of Islamic civilization?

Introduction

Abu Ja'far al-Mansur was the second leader (Caliph) of the Abbasid Empire, and he ruled from 754 to 775 CE. His older brother was actually the first leader, but historians say that al-Mansur was the **"real founder"** of the empire. When he took power, the government was very weak, unstable, and had many dangerous enemies. With his strong mind and smart plans, he turned a weak group into a

powerful global empire. He also started the famous **Islamic Golden Age**, which changed the history of Islamic civilization forever.

Why Al-Mansur is the "Real Founder"

- **1. Stopping Internal Enemies:** When al-Mansur became the leader, many powerful people tried to take his throne. He acted quickly and stopped them. He defeated his own powerful uncle, Abdallah. He also killed **Abu Muslim al-Khorasani**, who was a very powerful general from the Abbasid revolution. By removing these dangerous people, al-Mansur kept all the power in his own hands.
- **2. Crushing Big Revolts:** The family of Ali (the Alids) felt that the Abbasids had cheated them to take power. They started a big rebellion against al-Mansur in Medina and Basra. Al-Mansur used his strong army to stop these revolts completely. This made his position as the supreme leader very safe and clear to everyone.
- **3. Building the City of Baghdad:** In 762 CE, al-Mansur decided to move the capital city to a safer place. He built a brand-new city called **Baghdad**. He designed it in a unique circular shape, which people called the "Round City." It had huge walls and deep water channels around it for safety. It was built near two big rivers, the Tigris and Euphrates, so it quickly became a famous center for trade, business, and military power.
- **4. Creating an Organized Government System:** Al-Mansur changed the way the government worked. He copied the Persian style of ruling and created organized departments (*Diwans*). He introduced the job of a *Vizier*, who acted like a Prime Minister to run the daily work. He also improved the postal and intelligence network (*Barid*) to spy on far-off governors and stop problems early.

His Role in the Development of Islamic Civilization

- **1. Starting the Translation Work:** Al-Mansur was a highly educated man. He loved science, math, medicine, and stars. He invited smart scholars from different countries to Baghdad. He asked them to translate important

books from Greek, Persian, and Indian languages into Arabic. This was the beginning of the **Translation Movement**. It helped create the famous "House of Wisdom" under the kings who came after him.

- **2. Welcoming Non-Arab Muslims:** The old Umayyad rulers only favored Arab people. Al-Mansur changed this rule. He opened the doors of the government, court, and military to non-Arab Muslims, especially **Persians**. Because of this, the Abbasid Empire became a rich, mixed society where a person's talent and education were more important than their family background.
- **3. Supporting Islamic Scholars and Laws:** Al-Mansur provided a safe environment and money for religious scholars to study. Even though he had difficult relationships with some scholars, his peaceful empire gave experts the time to write down and organize the rules of Islamic law (*Fiqh*). This allowed different schools of Islamic thinking to grow and mature.

Conclusion

In conclusion, Abu Ja'far al-Mansur did incredible work for Islamic history. He was a very tough and strict leader, but his strong decisions saved the Abbasid Empire from collapsing. By making the borders safe, stopping internal wars, fixing the economy, and building Baghdad, he brought long-lasting peace. His support for science, books, and teamwork among different cultures created the perfect foundation for the glorious Islamic Golden Age.

5. Evaluate the contributions of Muslim scholars to the development of Geography and Mathematics. How has modern civilization benefited from these scientific contributions?

Introduction

During the Islamic Golden Age (8th to 14th century), Muslim scholars made great discoveries in science. They completely changed Mathematics and Geography. Instead of just copying old ideas, they fixed mistakes and created new systems. Today's world of computers, maps, and travel exists because of their smart work.

Contributions of Muslim Scholars to Mathematics

- **1. Invention of Algebra:** The word comes from the Arabic word *Al-Jabr*. A Persian mathematician named **Al-Khwarizmi** wrote the first book on algebra. He showed how to solve equations using rules and balancing methods.
- **2. Arabic Numerals and Zero:** Muslim scholars brought the number system (0, 1, 2, 3...) from India and spread it to Europe. They made the concept of **Zero** popular, which made big calculations much easier than using old Roman numbers.
- **3. Birth of Algorithms:** Al-Khwarizmi created step-by-step rules to solve math problems. The modern word "**Algorithm**" comes directly from his name, Al-Khwarizmi.
- **4. Advances in Trigonometry:** Scholars like **Al-Battani** made trigonometry a separate science. They created formulas for sines and cosines to calculate angles and distances accurately.

Contributions of Muslim Scholars to Geography

- **1. Accurate World Maps:** A geographer named **Al-Idrisi** created a highly advanced world map in the 12th century. It was the most detailed and correct map used by travelers for over 300 years.

- **2. Measuring the Earth:** A genius named **Al-Biruni** used math and trigonometry to calculate the size of the Earth. His calculation was amazingly correct, missing the modern measurement by less than 1%.
- **3. Latitude and Longitude:** Muslim travelers made exact tables showing the coordinates (latitude and longitude) of hundreds of cities. This helped people find the exact direction of Mecca from anywhere.
- **4. Better Navigation Tools:** They greatly improved the **Astrolabe** (a tool to find position using stars) and the sea compass. This made long-distance travel across oceans safe and easy.

How Modern Civilization Benefited

Modern society runs on the foundations laid down by these scholars:

- **Computers and Technology:** Every computer and smartphone runs on **algorithms**. Without Al-Khwarizmi's work on algorithms and zero, digital technology would not exist.
- **GPS and Travel:** Phone maps, airplanes, and ships use the concepts of latitude, longitude, and trigonometry developed by Al-Biruni and Al-Battani.
- **Engineering:** Building modern skyscrapers, bridges, and roads requires advanced math and trigonometry that grew during the Islamic Golden Age.
- **Trade and Money:** The simple number system (0-9) makes global banking, business, and shopping fast and error-free.

Conclusion

In conclusion, early Muslim scholars built a bridge between ancient knowledge and modern science. By creating algebra, using zero, drawing accurate maps, and measuring the Earth, they shaped our modern life. Modern civilization did not start from scratch; it stands on the brilliant discoveries of the Islamic Golden Age.

6. **“The reign of Al-Ma'mun was unquestionably the most brilliant and glorious period in the history of Islam.” Evaluate this statement with pragmatic reasons?**

Introduction

Al-Ma'mun was the seventh Caliph of the Abbasid Dynasty, ruling from 813 to 833 CE. He was the son of the famous Caliph Harun al-Rashid. Many historians agree that his 20-year reign represents the absolute peak of the **Islamic Golden Age**. The statement describing his era as "the most brilliant and glorious period in the history of Islam" is highly accurate when we look at his incredible support for science, philosophy, and education. He did not just expand the empire's land; he expanded the human mind.

Here is a pragmatic evaluation of why his reign was so brilliant, along with a few challenges he faced.

Pragmatic Reasons Behind His Glorious Reign

- **1. The Expansion of the House of Wisdom (*Bayt al-Hikmah*):**

While his father started it, Al-Ma'mun turned the House of Wisdom in Baghdad into a world-class grand academy and library. He gathered the best Muslim, Christian, Jewish, and Persian scholars under one roof. He valued books so much that he famously paid translators the exact **weight of their translated books in pure gold**.

- **2. Funding Major Scientific Projects:**

Al-Ma'mun was deeply passionate about astronomy, geography, and mathematics. He built the first official **astronomical observatories** in Baghdad and Damascus. He ordered a team of geographers to measure the circumference of the Earth and draw a highly detailed, updated map

of the world. He also personally sponsored the legendary mathematician **Al-Khwarizmi**, who invented Algebra during his reign.

- **3. The Great Translation Movement:**

Under his leadership, the state launched an organized project to collect and translate the world's knowledge. Scholars translated priceless manuscripts from Greek, Sanskrit, Persian, and Syriac into Arabic. Because of this, the works of ancient philosophers like Aristotle and Plato were saved from being lost to history.

- **4. Promoting Reason and Logic (*Mu'tazilism*):**

Al-Ma'mun believed that religion and human reason should work together. He supported a school of Islamic thought called *Mu'tazilism*, which used logic and philosophy to understand theological questions. This intellectual approach encouraged debate, scientific questioning, and independent thinking across the empire.

- **5. Economic Prosperity and Paper Making:**

His reign was a time of massive wealth and stable trade along the Silk Road. Crucially, the mass production of **paper** became widespread in Baghdad. This made books much cheaper to produce, leading to the opening of public libraries and a huge increase in literacy among everyday citizens.

A Balanced Evaluation (The Darker Side)

To evaluate his reign pragmatically, we must also look at his major mistake:

- **The *Mihna* (The Inquisition):**

Because Al-Ma'mun was so passionate about *Mu'tazilism*, he tried to force all Islamic scholars to accept its theological views by law. Those who disagreed—such as the famous scholar Ahmad ibn Hanbal—were

imprisoned or tortured. This state-enforced Inquisition created deep religious tension and damaged his reputation as a completely tolerant leader.

Conclusion

In conclusion, the reign of Al-Ma'mun was undoubtedly one of the most brilliant periods in world history. By investing the state's wealth into books, observatories, and universities rather than just military wars, he created an intellectual superpower. While his enforcement of the *Mihna* remains a dark spot on his political record, his immense contributions to algebra, astronomy, and world literature laid the direct foundations for both the Islamic Golden Age and the European Renaissance.

7. Appreciate the contributions of Muslims to the development of Geography and Astronomy. How is modern civilization indebted to these developments?

Introduction

During the Islamic Golden Age, Muslim scientists made breathtaking advancements in the fields of Geography and Astronomy. Motivated by both religious needs—such as finding the exact direction of Mecca and calculating prayer times—and pure curiosity, these scholars completely changed how humans viewed the Earth and the sky. They corrected old errors from Greek books, built massive research observatories, and invented precise tracking tools. Modern civilization is deeply indebted to their brilliant discoveries.

Contributions of Muslim Scholars to Geography

- **1. Highly Advanced Mapping (Al-Idrisi):**

In the 12th century, a famous Muslim geographer named **Al-Idrisi** drew the *Tabula Rogeriana*, which was the most accurate and detailed world

map of the medieval era. It featured major continents, rivers, and trade routes, and it served global travelers and kings for more than 300 years.

- **2. Measuring the Exact Size of the Earth (Al-Biruni):**

Long before modern satellites and airplanes were invented, a genius polymath named **Al-Biruni** used basic trigonometry to measure the circumference (the total distance around) of the Earth. His mathematical calculation was unbelievably precise, missing the modern satellite measurement by less than 1 percent.

- **3. Perfecting Long-Distance Coordinates:**

Muslim travelers explored vast distances across Asia, Africa, and Europe. To stay organized, geographers created detailed charts showing the **latitude and longitude** of hundreds of international cities, ensuring traders and pilgrims never got lost.

Contributions of Muslim Scholars to Astronomy

- **1. Discovering and Naming Stars (Al-Sufi):**

A brilliant astronomer named **Al-Sufi** wrote the famous *Book of Fixed Stars*. He thoroughly updated old star maps, corrected brightness levels, and identified brand-new constellations. In fact, many star names used by modern space agencies today—such as **Aldebaran, Altair, and Betelgeuse**—come directly from the Arabic names given by Muslim astronomers.

- **2. Correcting the Solar Year (Al-Battani):**

An expert astronomer named **Al-Battani** calculated the length of a solar year with incredible accuracy. He concluded that a year lasts 365 days, 5 hours, 46 minutes, and 24 seconds. His precise data was highly praised by major European scientists like Copernicus centuries later.

- **3. Creating the First Research Observatories:**

Muslim rulers funded the world's first modern **astronomical observatories**, such as the famous Maragheh Observatory. These were not just lookout points; they were large research institutions equipped with massive instruments where scientists tracked planetary movements daily.

- **4. Perfecting the Astrolabe:**

Muslim engineers took an ancient Greek invention called the **Astrolabe** and turned it into a highly complex, portable mechanical computer. They used it to determine time, predict the movements of stars, calculate latitudes, and navigate safely at night.

How Modern Civilization is Indebted to These Developments

The modern world relies heavily on the structural foundations laid down by these early Muslim thinkers:

- **GPS and Smart Maps:** The global tracking systems inside our smartphones, airplanes, and military ships run on the exact grid systems of **latitude and longitude** perfected by early Muslim geographers.
- **Modern Space Exploration:** Modern astronomy, satellite launches, and deep-space telescope projects still utilize the star coordinates, calculations of the solar year, and celestial maps built by Al-Sufi and Al-Battani.
- **Oceanic Travel and Commerce:** The improvements made to the astrolabe and the sea compass allowed European explorers to navigate open oceans safely, directly launching the age of global exploration and trade.

Conclusion

In conclusion, the scientific efforts of early Muslim geographers and astronomers served as a vital bridge to our modern world. They did not just gaze at stars or draw maps for their own time; they established the structural rules of observation, math-based navigation, and institutional research. Modern

civilization did not create its navigation apps or space programs from nothing—it stands directly on the brilliant and lasting legacy of the Islamic Golden Age.

8. Write short notes on any two of the following:

- Conquest of India during the reign of Al-Walid I
- Conquest of Spain during the reign of Al-Walid I
- Foreign Policy of Harun al-Rashid
- Bayt al-Hikmah
- Status of non-Muslims during the Umayyad Caliphate

1. Conquest of India during the reign of Al-Walid I

The Background and Cause

During the rule of Umayyad Caliph Al-Walid I, the Islamic empire was expanding very fast. A powerful governor named Al-Hajjaj ibn Yusuf was ruling Iraq and the eastern lands. At that time, a king named Raja Dahir was ruling Sindh (now in Pakistan).

The trouble started when sea pirates from Sindh attacked and robbed Muslim merchant ships. These ships were carrying gifts and orphan girls sent by the King of Sri Lanka to the Caliph. Governor Hajjaj sent a letter to Raja Dahir, asking him to rescue the girls and punish the pirates. But Raja Dahir replied that he had no control over the pirates. This made Hajjaj very angry, and he decided to send an army.

The Military Campaign (711–712 CE)

Hajjaj chose his 17-year-old nephew and son-in-law, **Muhammad bin Qasim**, to lead the army. Even though Qasim was very young, he was an incredibly smart military general. He marched into India with 6,000 elite soldiers and heavy weapons, including giant stone-throwing machines called *Manjaniks*.

- **First Victory:** Qasim first captured the port city of Debal and rescued the captured Muslim women.
- **The Final Battle:** Next, he crossed the Indus River to face Raja Dahir. In a fierce battle, Raja Dahir was killed, and his army panicked.
- **Capturing More Cities:** Qasim quickly took control of major cities like Brahmanabad, Alor, and Multan (which was famous as the "City of Gold" because of its immense wealth).

The Impact

Muhammad bin Qasim established a very fair and peaceful government. He told the local Hindus and Buddhists that they could practice their religion freely. This historic event opened the doors of South Asia to Islam and started a long era of Muslim culture and rule in India.

2. Conquest of Spain during the reign of Al-Walid I

The Background and Cause

In the early 8th century, Spain (the Iberian Peninsula) was ruled by a Visigothic Christian king named Roderick. He was a very cruel tyrant, and the local people, especially the Jews, were suffering under his rule.

The Umayyad governor of North Africa, Musa ibn Nusayr, saw an opportunity to bring justice and expand the empire. A local ruler from the city of Ceuta, named Count Julian, also hated King Roderick and asked the Muslims for help to overthrow him.

The Dramatic Landing (711 CE)

Musa sent his top general, **Tariq ibn Ziyad**, with a small army of 7,000 Berber Muslim soldiers. Tariq crossed the narrow sea between Africa and Europe and landed near a giant rock. Today, that place is named **Gibraltar** in his honor (which comes from *Jabal Tariq*, meaning the "Mountain of Tariq").

The Burning of the Ships: Tariq knew his army was very small compared to King Roderick's massive force. To stop his men from feeling afraid, he ordered them to **burn all their own ships**. He then gave a historic speech: *"O my warriors, where can you run? The sea is behind you, and the enemy is in front of you! By Allah, you only have your bravery and your swords left!"*

The Battle and Results

Tariq's brave men met King Roderick's army at the **Battle of Guadalete**. Despite being outnumbered, the Muslims won a spectacular victory, and King Roderick drowned in the river while trying to escape.

Hearing of this success, Governor Musa ibn Nusayr arrived with more soldiers. Together, they captured major cities like Toledo, Cordoba, and Seville. Within a few years, almost the entire region of Spain and Portugal came under Muslim control.

The Impact

This newly conquered land was named **Al-Andalus**. Under Muslim rule, Spain became the most beautiful, advanced, and educated place in Europe, filled with grand libraries, free universities, and beautiful architecture.

3. Foreign Policy of Harun al-Rashid

Harun al-Rashid (786–809 CE) was the most famous and powerful Abbasid Caliph. He did not just focus on wars; he used a brilliant mix of strong military force and smart diplomacy (friendly relationships) to handle foreign nations.

War with the Byzantine Empire

The Byzantines (the Eastern Roman Empire) were the biggest enemies of the Abbasids. Initially, the Byzantine Empress, Irene, made a peace treaty with Harun and paid a yearly tax (tribute) to Baghdad.

However, a new emperor named Nikephoros I took power. He broke the treaty and sent a highly insulting letter to Harun, demanding that the Muslims return all the tax money.

Harun al-Rashid became furious. He wrote an iconic, short reply on the back of the same letter:

"From Harun, the Commander of the Faithful, to Nikephoros, the dog of the Romans. I have read your letter. You will not hear my answer, you will see it with your own eyes!"

Harun personally led a massive army into Byzantine territory, completely defeated Emperor Nikephoros, and forced him to sign a new treaty and pay even higher taxes.

Friendship with Charlemagne (Holy Roman Empire)

Harun used the classic rule of politics: *"The enemy of my enemy is my friend."* He knew that Charlemagne, the Emperor of Western Europe, was an enemy of both the Byzantines and the Umayyads in Spain.

Therefore, Harun established a very close, friendly alliance with Charlemagne. They exchanged ambassadors and sent each other magnificent gifts. Harun sent Charlemagne rich silks, perfumes, a complicated automatic water clock that amazed the Europeans, and a rare white Asian elephant named *Abul-Abbas*.

Relationship with China

Harun al-Rashid also established friendly diplomatic ties with the Tang Dynasty of China. By maintaining peace with China, he secured the famous **Silk Road** trade routes. This allowed Muslim merchants to travel and trade safely all the way to East Asia, making Baghdad incredibly rich.

4. Bayt al-Hikmah (The House of Wisdom)

The Origin and Growth

The **Bayt al-Hikmah** was a grand institution in Baghdad that served as a library, a university, and a scientific research center. It started as a small royal library under Caliph Harun al-Rashid to hold his collection of books.

However, it reached its magnificent peak under his son, **Caliph Al-Ma'mun**, in the 9th century. Al-Ma'mun was obsessed with education and science, and he spent a huge amount of state money to turn this library into the center of world knowledge.

The Great Translation Movement

Al-Ma'mun wanted to gather all the scientific and philosophical knowledge in the world and translate it into Arabic. He sent teams of scholars to Greece, Egypt, Persia, and India to buy old, priceless manuscripts.

To motivate the translators, the Caliph offered an incredible reward: **he paid them the exact weight of each translated book in pure gold!** Scholars successfully translated major works on mathematics, medicine, astronomy, and philosophy from Greek, Sanskrit, Persian, and Syriac.

A Center for New Discoveries

The House of Wisdom was not just a place for translating old books. Brilliant scientists lived and worked there to create brand-new fields of science:

- **Al-Khwarizmi** worked here and invented **Algebra** and developed the concept of algorithms.
- Astronomers used the library's data to build advanced observatories to study the stars and planets.
- Medical experts wrote advanced textbooks that were used to train doctors for hundreds of years.

The Sad Ending (1258 CE)

The House of Wisdom operated as a global lighthouse of knowledge for over 400 years. Sadly, in 1258 CE, the fierce Mongol army led by Hulagu Khan

attacked and destroyed Baghdad. They burned the building and threw millions of rare books into the Tigris River. Historians write that the river ran completely black for days from the ink of the destroyed books, marking a tragic end to the Islamic Golden Age.

5. Status of Non-Muslims during the Umayyad Caliphate

The Umayyad Caliphate (661–750 CE) ruled over a massive territory filled with millions of non-Muslim citizens, including Christians, Jews, and Zoroastrians.

The Legal Status of "Dhimmi"

Under Islamic law, non-Muslim citizens living in a Muslim state were officially classified as *Dhimmis* (which means "Protected People"). The Umayyad government was legally responsible for protecting their lives, their properties, and their honor.

Religious and Personal Freedom

Non-Muslims enjoyed a high level of freedom inside the empire:

- **Freedom of Worship:** They were allowed to keep their churches, synagogues, and temples, and practice their religious rituals openly.
- **Own Legal Courts:** They had autonomy over their personal lives. For example, if two Christian citizens had a family dispute or a business argument, they did not have to go to an Islamic court. They could go to their own church leaders, who judged the case using Christian laws.

The Jizya Tax

In return for state protection and safety, and because they were exempt from serving in the Muslim military, healthy non-Muslim men had to pay a yearly tax called the *Jizya*.

It is important to know that the *Jizya* was very fair: it was **only** collected from adult, healthy men who could earn money. Women, children, old people, the

poor, disabled citizens, and Christian monks were completely exempt from paying it.

The Political Challenges

While the foundational laws were fair, the actual practice varied under different Umayyad caliphs:

- **Arab Favoritism:** The Umayyad dynasty was highly centered around Arab nationalism. They favored Arab elites over everyone else.
- **The Mawali Problem:** When non-Arab people (like Persians) converted to Islam, some greedy Umayyad governors still forced them to pay the *Jizya* because they did not want the state treasury to lose tax money. This unfair practice violated Islamic principles and caused widespread public anger.
- **The Reform:** This discrimination was temporarily stopped by the holy Caliph **Umar ibn Abdul Aziz**, who restored absolute equality for all citizens, regardless of their race or religion.